Michael F Bergmann

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a) Name

Bergmann, Michael F. — Associate Professor, Performance, The Creative School, Toronto Metropolitan University

b) Degrees

2022-09 – present	PhD Candidate, Critical Studies in Improvisation, University of Guelph. Expected 2027.
2011 – 2014	MFA, Design (Projection Design Specialization), Yale School of Drama, Yale University
2006 – 2011	BFA, Theatre Performance Production, Ryerson Theatre School, Toronto Metropolitan University (coursework completed December 2010; graduated May 2011)

c) Employment History

2024-01 – present	Associate Professor (Tenured), Performance, The Creative School, Toronto Metropolitan University
2022-07 – 2023-07	Co-Undergraduate Program Director (Production), Performance, The Creative School, TMU
2019-08 – 2024-01	Assistant Professor, Performance, The Creative School, Toronto Metropolitan University
2017 – present	Full Member, Yeates School of Graduate Studies, TMU
2016-08 – 2019-08	Assistant Professor (Limited Term Faculty), Performance, The Creative School, TMU
2014 – 2016	Technology Specialist / Media Server Programmer, WorldStage LAB, San Francisco / New York
2007 – 2010	Projection Specialist, Meet The Dude Productions, Toronto

d) Honours

2022	Best World Feature Film: Nuptials, Austin Revolution Film Festival (as producer)
2014	Best Production: He Left Quietly, SummerWorks Performance Festival (as designer)
2012 – 2014	Eldon Elder Fellowship, Yale University ($40,000 USD; held throughout the MFA)

2009	Spirit of the Fringe, Prague Fringe Festival
2006	Short-listed, Prix Molière, Theatre Glendon

e) Scholarly and Professional Academic Activities

2026	Reviewer, NeurIPS Creative AI Track 2026: Agency, Thirty-Ninth Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems
2026-09 – present	School of Performance representative, TFA Representative's Council, TMU
2026-06 – present	Judge, Music, Film & Theatre panel, The Global Undergraduate Awards, Dublin
2026-04	Co-chair (with Dr. Afsoon Soudi), 3rd Annual Creative AI Symposium, Creative AI Hub, TMU
2025-07 – present	Member, Creative AI Hub Steering Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2025-02 – present	Member, USITT Research and Creative Endeavours Committee
2024-12 – present	Member, Faculty Tenure Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2025-04 – present	Board Member, UKAI Projects
2024-06 – present	Reviewer, International Journal of Performance Arts and Digital Media
2023-10 – present	Jury Member, CATR Scholarship and Grant Committee (Heather McCallum Scholarship, Robert Lawrence Scholarship, CATR Grants)
2023 – present	Reviewer, EVA London Conference on Electronic Visualisation and the Arts
2023 – 2024	Technical Advisory Board Member, UKAI Projects
2023 – 2024	Member, 360 Working Group, School of Performance, TMU
2023	Reviewer, Canada Foundation for Innovation
2022 – 2024	Senator (The Creative School faculty representative), TMU Senate
2022-03 – 2023	Secretary of the Board, Guild Festival Theatre
2021 – 2022	Member, Immersive Production Steering Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2021	Member, Name Implementation Advisory Group (FCAD renaming to The Creative School), TMU
2020 – 2023	Member, Gold Medal selection committee (FCAD/Creative School section), TMU
2020 – 2021	Member, Departmental Hiring Committee, Performance, TMU
2020 – present	Coordinator, Global Campus Studio course, TMU
2020	Member, FCAD Virtual Task Force, TMU
2020-09 – 2021-09	Member, Limited Return of Human Participant & Field SRC Activity Advisory Group, TMU
2019 – 2022	Member, Academic Integrity Committee, TMU
2018 – 2022	School of Performance representative, RFA (now TFA) Representative's Council, TMU

2018 – 2023	Member, Creative Innovation Studio Curatorial Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2018 – 2020	FCAD Teaching Committee; FCAD Interdisciplinary Advisory Committee
2017 – present	Member, Curriculum Committee, School of Performance, TMU
2017 – present	Member, Production Department Committee, School of Performance, TMU
2016 – 2021	Member, Stage Committee, Arts & Letters Club of Toronto

f) Graduate Supervisions

Completed: 9 Master's, 0 Doctoral, 0 Postdoctoral. In progress: 0.

2022	Aya Elmeligy, MDM (Second Reader), "Bridging Chasms: An Interactive Projection Mapping Installation for Cross-Cultural Exchange of Information." 2022.
2021	Emilie Trimbee, MDM (Supervisor), "AR-based Theatrical Design Pre-Visualization using Unreal." 2021.
2021	Lindsay Christopher, MDM (Supervisor), "Casting and Technology: Revamping the Audition Process." 2021.
2021	Shelby Bushell, MDM (Supervisor), "Collider: Using Virtual Reality for Immersive Theatre and the Performing Arts." 2021.
2020	Riley Erin Cooper, MDM (Supervisor), "Happiness In Your Hand: The power of compact Bright Light Therapy." 2020.
2020	Yerachmiel Paquette, MDM (Supervisor), "The Scoop: How to Protect Your Digital Privacy in the Age of Surveillance Capitalism." 2020.
2020	Kenyth Thomason, MFA in Technical Direction and Production, Yale University (Reader), "Live Video in Theatrical Productions." 2020.
2018	Michael Castledine, MDM (Supervisor), "Extending the human umwelt: Reframing our understanding of an environment via mixed reality and digital soundscapes/visualizations." 2018.
2017	Soo Mahabir, MDM (Supervisor), "The A.I. Storyteller: Perpetuating Orality Using Developments in Machine Learning." 2017.

g) Graduate Courses

None — the School of Performance offers no graduate program; graduate work is supervised through the Master of Digital Media program (see f).

h) Research Funding

1. External Research Funding

Year	Source	Program	Type*	Amount	PI	Purpose**
2024	European Union / OAMK	Erasmus+ staff mobility	G	—	Michael Bergmann	Travel
2021	SSHRC	Partnership Engage Grant, COVID-19 Special Initiative	C	$24,620	Cintia Cristiá	Research
2012	Yale University	Eldon Elder Fellowship	O	$40,000 USD	Michael Bergmann	Fellowship

*Type: C – Granting Councils; G – Government; F – Foundations; O – Other
**Purpose: research, travel, publication, etc.

2. Internal Research Funding

Year	Source	Program	Type*	Amount	PI	Purpose**
2024	TMU	The Creative School Travel Grant	O	$1,000	Michael Bergmann	Travel
2022	TMU	Work Study RA Program	O	$3,800	Michael Bergmann	Research
2022	TMU	The Creative School Travel Grant	O	$2,000	Michael Bergmann	Travel
2019	Cirque du Soleil Entertainment Group / Ryerson	Future of Live Entertainment Lab	O	$7,500	Co-I with Jonathon Anderson	Research
2019	Ryerson	FCAD Special Seed Grant	O	$4,000	Michael Bergmann	Research
2019	Ryerson	The Creative School Travel Grant	O	$2,000	Michael Bergmann	Travel
2018	Ryerson	Undergraduate Research Opportunity, OVPRI	O	$9,888	Michael Bergmann	Research
2018	Ryerson	Learning and Teaching Enhancement Fund	O	$13,000	Pavlo Bosyy	Research

*Type: C – Granting Councils; G – Government; F – Foundations; O – Other
**Purpose: research, travel, publication, etc.

i) Publications

Life-time summary

- Books authored: 0
- Books edited: 0
- Chapters in books: 0
- Papers in refereed journals: 0
- Papers in refereed conference proceedings: 1
- Major invited contributions and/or technical reports: 0
- Abstracts and/or papers read: 21
- Other (data sets, magazine and literary publications): 3

Papers in refereed conference proceedings

2022-07 Bouchard, D., Cristiá, C., Robert, D., and Bergmann, M. (2022). "Augmented Symphony: An augmented reality application for immersive music listening." Proceedings of EVA London 2022, Electronic Workshops in Computing, BCS Learning & Development, London, UK, July 4–8, 2022, pp. 208–209. DOI: 10.14236/ewic/EVA2022.39.

Abstracts and/or papers read

2025-09 Bergmann, M. "Hallucinating Children: Improvisation After the Algorithmic Shipwreck." Hugarflug: Unstable Systems, annual conference on artistic research, Iceland University of the Arts, Reykjavík, Iceland, September 12, 2025.

2024-10 Bergmann, M. "Beyond Tools: Reimaging Technology as Co-Participants in Performance Design." PQ Symposium: Technologies in Theatre, Performance and Exhibition Design, Prague, Czech Republic, October 16–18, 2024.

2024-03 Bergmann, M., Nathan, H., and Vercosa, J. "Robotics, AI, and the Future of Theatre." USITT Conference & Stage Expo, Seattle, WA, March 20, 2024.

2024-01 Bergmann, M., Carravetta, L., Endahl, M., Robinson, A. D., and ARIA (AI). "Almost Alchemy." Poster, RUBIX, TMU, January 25, 2024.

2023-06 Bergmann, M., with ChatGPT. "Envisioning theatre with non-human collaborators: A Paramanifesto." CATR Conference, Dalhousie University, Halifax, NS, June 2023.

2023-06 Bergmann, M. "AI Sentience." Panel on the Implications of AI for Performance Theorists, CATR Conference (online), June 2023.

2022-07 Bergmann, M. "Augmented Symphony: An augmented reality application for immersive music listening." Paper presented at EVA London 2022, London, UK, July 2022.

2022-05	Bergmann, M., and Thomson, B. “Stepping Back In: Taking the best of virtual delivery to a new in-person experience.” Learning & Teaching Conference, TMU, May 2022.
2022-05	Bergmann, M. “Student-driven curriculum development for creative practice.” Learning & Teaching Conference, TMU, May 2022.
2021-10	Bergmann, M. “Cultivating Empathy through Robotic Performance.” Limits of the Human, Machines Without Limits? Contemporary stage and robotics, University of Lausanne (online), October 2021.
2021-06	Bergmann, M., O’Brien, C., and Thomson, B. “Unapologetically learning together: Adapting Production and Design curriculum to a virtual stage.” University of the Arts London (online), June 2021.
2021-05	Bergmann, M., O’Brien, C., and Thomson, B. “Pandemic Performance: Adapting Production and Design curriculum to a virtual stage.” Learning & Teaching Conference, Ryerson University, May 2021.
2020-11	Bergmann, M., and Anderson, J. “l’automate: Robotic Controlled Apparatuses for Circus Performance.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU (online), November 2020.
2019-11	Bergmann, M., Zhang, L., Laberge-Côté, L., and McGuire, B. “Human-robot Interactions in Dance.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, November 2019.
2019-05	Bergmann, M., and Thomson, B. “Putting Up the Show: The very large group project.” Ryerson Learning & Teaching Conference, May 2019.
2019-04	Bergmann, M. “Theatre in TheatAR: Explorations of augmented reality in theatrical performance.” TEXT/SOUND/PERFORMANCE: Making in Canadian Space, University College Dublin, April 2019.
2018-11	Bergmann, M. “TheatAR: A previsualization system for theatrical design.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, November 2018.
2018-05	Bosyy, P., and Bergmann, M. “The Creative Laboratory Project.” Poster, Ryerson Learning & Teaching Conference, May 2018.
2018-03	Bergmann, M. “Technology as a tool: Creating a mindset of embracing technology within a theatrical framework.” Theatre and Performance Design Pedagogy, University of the Arts London, March 2018.
2017-10	Bergmann, M. “Shadow-selves: Projection as a medium of exploring reflections of self in Belinda McGuire’s Slaughterhouse/Requiem.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, October 2017.
2017-10	Bergmann, M. “Projecting on film: the surreal effect of rear projected backgrounds in the film Nuptials.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, October 2017.

Other (data sets, magazine and literary publications)

2022-05 Cristiá, C., Bouchard, D., Bergmann, M., et al. (2022). Orchestra Remote Delivery during COVID-19 Database. Open data set, Open Science Framework, May 5, 2022. DOI: 10.17605/OSF.IO/WCDU2.

2021 Bergmann, M. F., and McGuire, B. (2021). "Uncanny Text." Belfield Literary Review: New TransAtlantic Dialogues, ed. Gregory Betts and Lucy Collins, Spring 2021, pp. 96–99.

2017-11 Bergmann, M. F. (2017). "Performance Art: New Magic." Rough Draft, Vol. 2, No. 1, ed. Laurence Butet-Roch, November 7, 2017.

Submitted and in-press (listed separately per OCGS instructions)

2026 Bergmann, M. "Cultivating Empathy through Robotic Performance." Chapter in Robots and Other Artificial Agents on Stage: Theoretical Concepts and Artistic Practices, edited by Erica Magris and Izabella Pluta, transcript Verlag (Theatre Studies series). [in press]

2026 Bergmann, M., and McLeod, K. "Improvising with Commercial AI: Questions of Care and Ethics." [in draft]

Creative and Professional Work

2026-04 – 2026-05 "Before I Was This." Generative text work. flashDRIVE: Digital Arts Fundraiser Exhibition, InterAccess, Toronto, April 22 – May 9, 2026. Curated by Miriam Arbus.

2026-02 Nuptials (feature film). Producer, projection design, and live in-camera VFX. Directed by Sean Braune, Para-sight Productions. Official release February 13, 2026 (Freestyle Digital Media). Best World Feature Film, Austin Revolution Film Festival, 2022.

2025-11 The Frankenstein Project. Producer, with Debashis Sinha. Performance Studio Theatre, TMU, November 18–22, 2025.

2025-11 291 by Jade O'Keeffe. Projection co-design with Kristen Ferguson; directed by Lisa Dixon. Peterborough Theatre Guild, November 1–15, 2025.

2025-04 "To my creators…" Solo work exhibited at the Creative AI Symposium, TMU, April 2, 2025; created during the SÍM residency, Reykjavík.

2024-11 AVARA 2024 installation. Led eight students in a semester-long research-creation installation presented at AVARA 2024, OAMK, Oulu, Finland.

2024-06 Shipwreck. Group exhibition with UKAI Projects and five Canadian artists, SÍM Gallery, Reykjavík, Iceland, following a month-long residency; includes solo work "To my creators…"

2024-04	Labour and Us. Workshop series (March 14 – April 17, 2024) and performance, co-created and performed with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson; roundtable with Alan Filewod, Tom Scholte, Cynthia Ashperger, and Judith Thompson. ImprovLab, University of Guelph, April 19, 2024.
2024-01	Almost Alchemy. Two 360° video experiences of improvised research-creation performance. RUBIX, TMU, January 25, 2024.
2023-10	"rocketmanperson." Improvised performance with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson. Silence, Guelph, October 1, 2023.
2023-04	"Who's There?" Improvised performance with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson. Silence, Guelph, April 1, 2023.
2023	Living Newspaper 2.0. Projection design; directed by Julie Labagnara. George Luscombe Theatre, Toronto.
2019-10	"The Uncanny Robots Project: Phase 1." Research-creation premiere examining human-robot interaction through dance, commissioned for the opening of the Creative Technology Lab @ FCAD, TMU, October 2019.